HAMASPIK LEOVDEI HASHEM

Why Work If Hashem Feeds All? Is Bitahon Natural or Earned?

Given Monday 6 July 2026 · HaMaspik LeOvdei HaShem 8.6

Sefer: HaMaspik L'Ovdei Hashem (Kifayat al-Abidin) — Rabbi Avraham ben HaRambam **Chapter:** Perek 8 (ביטחון — Bitachon and Reliance) — Part 6 **This Week:** The Two Questions on Bitachon and Their Answers · Compelled vs. Voluntary Bitachon · Everything Traces Back to Hashem (the Suckling Analogy) · Which Jobs Make Bitachon Easier or Harder

(Schedule: this Thursday shiur replaces Hilchot Shabbat to finish the bitachon chapter before the summer break — HaMaspik continues Monday, finishing the chapter the following Monday. Next Thursday: the Rambam's understanding of Tisha B'Av.)

Recap

- **Category 1** (serious danger): Tehillim, trust, prayer, every natural means. If a person truly lives with Hakadosh Baruch Hu, no danger can harm him (the snakes in Chukat after the teshuvah) — but never put yourself in danger: you may lack the merit, and even if saved, it deducts from your merits. In mortal *spiritual* danger, pray — and sometimes one must give up his life.
- **Category 2** (minor harms): do not employ bitachon (prayer is fine) unless one is of the greatest people — though **Rabbeinu Yonah in Mishlei disagrees** (a machloket Rishonim). In *spiritual* matters even small things can become very big, so bitachon is appropriate even for small spiritual dangers.
- **Category 3 begun** (achieving essential matters — basic bread, clothes, shelter): employ bitachon, pray, and request the basics, like Yaakov Avinu.

The five categories: (1) avoiding extremely harmful situations, (2) avoiding less harmful situations, (3) achieving the essential, (4) achieving the important-but-non-essential, (5) the non-important and non-essential.

Tonight: the two questions Rabbi Avraham raises in the middle of Category 3 — and his answers.

QUESTION 1 — If Hashem Feeds Even the Animals, Why Bitachon?

The Question

Many verses state Hashem grants basic parnasah **even to animals** — **זן מקרני ראמים עד ביצי כינים** (from the horns of wild oxen to the eggs of lice). If Hashem sustains all creatures anyway, **what practical need is there for humans to have bitachon?**

The Answer — Free Will Changes Everything

Even though **אף על פי שפרנסת הבריות מובטחת... הנה לפעמים גורם העוון לידי הכרתת הפרנסה** parnasah is guaranteed to creatures by nature — **sin can cause a person's parnasah to be cut off.**

The default position is indeed that Hashem feeds everyone. **But humans have bechirah — free will.** Our obedience or disobedience changes the parnasah in three directions:

Direction 1 — Aveirot Can Remove Parnasah Entirely

- The Torah's curses (Bechukotai etc.) explicitly warn of **famine** when we don't do Hashem's will

Direction 2 — Or Parnasah Comes, But Only Through Great Toil

- **Adam** after the sin: **בזעת אפך תאכל לחם... וקוץ ודרדר תצמיח לך** — you'll have bread, but by the sweat of your brow, with thorns and thistles
- **Kayin**: **כי תעבוד את האדמה לא תוסף תת כוחה לך** — the ground will no longer yield its strength to you

  you'll eat "the bread of sadness": parnasah delivered with difficulty and — **אוכלי לחם העצבים** turmoil
- **King Asa of Yehudah**: he turned to Ben-Hadad, king of Aram, for help against Baasha king of Israel — and the navi rebuked him: **בהישענך על מלך ארם ולא על ה' אלהיך** — *because you leaned on the king of Aram and not on Hashem your God.* When you relied on Hashem, He delivered the vast armies of the Kushim and Luvim into your hand; **כי ה' עיניו משוטטות בכל הארץ להתחזק עם לבבם שלם אליו** — Hashem's eyes rove the whole earth to strengthen those whose heart is complete with Him. **נסכלת על זאת — כי מעתה יש עמך מלחמות**: you acted foolishly; from now on you will have wars. *(Not total removal — but everything becomes a fight.)*

Direction 3 — Obedience Brings Broad, Easy Parnasah

וכנגד זה מביאה צייתות לסדר השם הרחבת הפרנסה וריבויה

- **Parshat Ekev**: **והיה עקב תשמעון... וברך פרי בטנך ופרי אדמתך דגנך ותירושך ויצהרך** — Hashem blesses land, grain, wine, oil, cattle
- The botei'ach is by definition obedient (bitachon presupposes and *is* obedience) — so Hashem rewards his bitachon with **easy parnasah**: **כן יתן לידידו שנא** — He gives to His beloved *in their sleep* (as explained a few weeks ago — you make your parnasah and sleep easily)

  those who seek Hashem lack no good — **ודורשי ה' לא יחסרו כל טוב**

The Contrast Verses (from Birkat Hamazon and Shabbat mornings)

What does "young lions went hungry" mean? **כפירים רשו ורעבו, ודורשי ה' לא יחסרו כל טוב**
Metzudat David: כפירים = **the wealthy and the great** — a metaphor. The wealthy went hungry *because they forgot Hashem and their bitachon*; while the seekers of Hashem lack nothing.

- **Chana**: **שבעים בלחם נשכרו** — those who were sated with bread ended up hiring themselves out (they lost their trust)
- **Doeg** (who maligned David to Shaul — initially a righteous talmid chacham): **גם אל יתצך לנצח... וישחקו עליו הנה הגבר לא ישים אלהים מעוזו, ויבטח ברוב עשרו** — God will tear him down forever, and the righteous will see and laugh: *behold the man who did not make God his stronghold, but trusted in his great wealth*

The Explicit Mishnah (Kiddushin 82) — Which the Avi Ezer Surprisingly Doesn't Bring

רבי שמעון בן אלעזר אומר: ראית מימיך חיה ועוף שיש להם אומנות? והן מתפרנסין שלא בצער. והלא לא נבראו אלא לשמשני, ואני נבראתי לשמש את קוני — אינו דין שאתפרנס שלא בצער? אלא שהרעותי את מעשי וקיפחתי את פרנסתי

Have you ever seen a beast or bird with a trade? Yet they are sustained without anguish. They were created to serve me, and I was created to serve my Maker — surely I should be sustained without anguish! But I ruined my deeds — and forfeited my parnasah.

The kal vachomer is exactly Rabbi Avraham's answer: animals have no free will, so their sustenance flows automatically; humans chose badly, and so parnasah became hard.

Summary of Question 1

Hashem gives parnasah to all — **but because of our free will, obedience improves and broadens our parnasah, while disobedience removes it or delivers it only through turmoil and hard work.** That is the practical need for bitachon.

QUESTION 2 — Is Bitachon Natural to Everyone, or Rare and Praiseworthy?

The Question

Verses imply trust in Hashem is **natural and universal** — most classically (said before eating bread, in Ashrei):

the eyes of ALL look hopefully to You — **עיני כל אליך ישברו ואתה נותן להם את אכלם בעתו**

But other verses **praise** the one who trusts — **אשרי אדם בוטח בך** — and **condemn** the one who doesn't — **הנה הגבר לא ישים אלהים מעוזו**. If everyone naturally has bitachon, why is it praised or its absence cursed? **The verses seem to contradict.**

Rabbi Avraham gives **two answers.**

ANSWER 1 — "Kol" Means Majority; Bitachon Can Be Compelled or Voluntary

Two introductions:

all" in Tanakh often means **the majority**" — **כל כוונתו רוב**

bitachon can be **compelled** or **voluntary** (and voluntary — **הביטחון יכול להיות הכרחי או רצוני**

bitachon can itself be **general** or **specific** — below)

Compelled Bitachon — "No Atheists in a Foxhole"

When life is good — wealth, health, everything — a person forgets Hashem. *(The Mesillat Yesharim discusses this: poverty is a great test of trust — but the Ramchal suggests the test of wealth is the greater one.)* Then the person **loses** the wealth or the health — and *now* he turns to Hashem:

When the wealthy and honored **בעלי עושר וכבוד... אם יתרוששו ויאבדו את עושרם וכבודם ישובו לביטחון**

lose their wealth and status — they *return* to bitachon. Not from free good will, but **compelled**

.was knocked away (עושר, כבוד, בריאות) **by circumstances** — their transient walking-stick

Compelled Bitachon Even Among Idolaters

ודבר זה מצוי תדיר אפילו אצל עובדי עבודה זרה

The Rambam's principle (opening of Hilchot Avodah Zarah): idolatry didn't begin with people believing idols have intrinsic power — it began with **intermediaries**: people who couldn't face approaching Hashem directly, so they put something in between. *(This is why Moshe broke the Luchot on 17 Tammuz — and why even today religious people cling to amulets, red strings, blue charms: an avoidance of direct communication with Hashem, placing trust in an intermediary. That, essentially, was the golden calf.)* Most ovdei avodah zarah serve their idols **in order to come closer to the true Savior**: **כי ביטחונם בפסיליהם... הוא אמצעי בינם ובין השם המושיע**.

Proof 1 — the sailors of Yonah: In the storm, **ויזעקו איש אל אלהיו** — each cried to his own god. But when Yonah told them **עברי אנכי ואת ה' אלהי השמים אני ירא** — **ויראו האנשים יראה גדולה** — they feared *Hashem*, and prayed to Him: **אנה ה' אל נא נאבדה בנפש האיש הזה**. A moment ago they were praying to idols — and they trace right back to Hakadosh Baruch Hu.

Proof 2 — Mesha, King of Moav: Under Israel's oppression he offered his firstborn son to his god — and there was **קצף גדול על ישראל** (Israel was blamed for having driven him to it). The horror doesn't contradict the fact that **כוונתו היתה לשם... בצרתו** — in his distress, his intent traced toward Heaven.

Hence **Yirmiyahu**: **מי לא יראך מלך הגוים כי לך יאתה** — who does not fear You, King of the nations — even idolaters ultimately trace back to You. And **David**: **מבטח כל קצוי ארץ וים רחוקים** — You are the trust of all the ends of the earth.

Voluntary Bitachon — The Choice of Yichidei Segulah

והביטחון הרצוני הוא ביטחונם של יחידי סגולה מיחדים את השם

Voluntary bitachon is **chosen** — not squeezed out by desperation: **דבקים בתורה, מאמינים באמת, וכל עניינם שהכל מכל מהשם יתברך** — they place their reliance on Hashem **even while they have wealth, health, strength, and status.**

Bitachon and Yichud Hashem: note the phrase מיחדים את השם — true bitachon *is* an expression of the unity of God. One who truly lives knowing that nothing can harm or help him apart from Hashem is living **שמע ישראל ה' אלהינו ה' אחד**. Bitachon strengthens yichud Hashem, and yichud Hashem strengthens bitachon.

Two Levels Within Voluntary Bitachon

Level	Description
הביטחון הכללי — general	The bitachon of ordinary people "in the thoughts of their hearts": we all *say* and *feel* we trust Hashem — though it may not manifest in our day-to-day activities. *(Even Sancheriv, despite his heresy, said **בלא ה' עליתי על המקום הזה** — he recognized his campaign came from Hashem.)*
הביטחון הפרטי — specific/rare	The bitachon of the special shomrei Torah **who live it every moment**: in every business dealing, every negotiation, their trust is in Hashem and not in their efforts — **בטח אל ה' בכל לבך ואל בינתך אל תשען... בכל דרכיך דעהו** — training every thought toward Hashem

(The avodah: never be compelled *into bitachon — choose it voluntarily; and then work to raise the general into the specific, so it manifests in everything we do.)*

The Resolution (Answer 1)

הפסוקים שבהם נאמר כי כל אחד בוטח בהשם — כוונתם לרוב בני אדם, והביטחון מהסוג המוכרח; והפסוקים האמורים על נדירותו של הביטחון — כגון אשרי אדם בוטח בך — כוונתם לביטחון הרצוני המובחר

"עיני כל אליך ישברו" = the **majority** of people do, at the end of the day, turn to Hashem — mostly **compelled** (when the going gets hard and there's no alternative)

"אשרי אדם בוטח בך" = praise for the one who **voluntarily chose** bitachon — that is the rare and praiseworthy kind

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ANSWER 2 — Kol Really Means ALL: Everyone Trusts in Something, and Everything Traces Back to Hashem

(Rabbi Avraham himself loves this answer — he closes it with "this is one of the beautiful and correct interpretations.")

כי כל הגורמים חוזרים אליו יתעלה... נמצא הבוטח באותו גורם סומך בטחונו עליו יתעלה — בין אם הבין זאת... או שלא הבין

Everyone trusts in someone or something — and that someone or something **traces back to Hashem**. So in effect, even without realizing it, **everyone indirectly trusts in Hashem.**

The Three Examples

You trust in...	But...	Verse
Your wealth	Hashem produced it — and guards it	**ה' מוריש ומעשיר, משפיל אף מרומם**; and for the oleh laregel: **ולא יחמוד איש את ארצך** (your Hashem guards your property while you're away)
Your strength / status	Hashem gave it	**וזכרת את ה' אלהיך כי הוא הנותן לך כח לעשות חיל**
Another person (your employer of thirty years)	Hashem created him, gives him life, and gives him his ability	**כי יוצר הכל הוא; אשר בידו נפש כל חי; והעושר והכבוד מלפניך**

Whether **הבוטח בגורמים האלו... הרי הוא סומך בטחונו עליו יתעלה — בין אם הבין... בין לא ידעו וכפר בו** you understand it, don't understand it, or even deny it — **the theoretical truth is you are trusting in Hashem.**

The Suckling Analogy (דומה לנער קטן)

One who doesn't grasp this is like a **baby at his mother's breast**:

1. **The infant** — all he knows is his mother's milk; as far as he's concerned, his mother is the source of everything
2. **The child (~5)** — matures a little: mother provides the food, but *from father's money*
3. **The teenager** — father's money comes *from his employer*

4. **The mature adult** — the employer, and everything, **traces back to Hashem**: **וכן הלאה עד שיבין ויתפוס שהכל מאת השם יתברך**

David HaMelech said it in his maturity about his own infancy:

You drew me from the **כי אתה גוחי מבטן, מבטיחי על שדי אמי; עליך השלכתי מרחם, מבטן אמי אלי אתה** *womb; You were my security ON MY MOTHER'S BREASTS — upon You I was cast from the womb.* As a suckling he couldn't picture it; grown, he recognized the truth: it was Hashem all along.

Extending It to the Animals — The Verses Finally Explained

Now those puzzling pesukim make sense. **When do ravens or lions "call to Hashem"?**

He gives the beast its bread, the young ravens *that* — **נותן לבהמה לחמה, לבני עורב אשר יקראו** *cal*

the lions roar for prey, *seeking their food from God* — **הכפירים שואגים לטרף — ולבקש מאל אכלם**

the ox knows its owner, the donkey its master's trough — **ידע שור קונהו וחמור אבוס בעליו**

The animal relies on whoever tends and feeds it (the sheep trusts the farmer) — **but the one it relies on depends on Hashem**: **הגורם שבו בוטחים הם תלוי בך, השם יתברך — והם לא יודעים זאת**. So **כולם אליך ישברון** is literal: ALL — humans and animals — trust in Hashem, most without knowing it.

Understand this and grasp it with" — **הבן את הדבר והשיגהו בשכלך, כי הוא מהפירושים היפים והנכונים** your mind, for it is one of the beautiful and correct interpretations".

The Resolution (Answer 2)

literally everyone (and everything): all trust *something*, and that = **"עיני כל אליך ישברו"** something traces back to Hashem — indirect, unknowing trust

- **The praise-verses** = those who trust Hashem **directly and knowingly** — cutting out the intermediary and placing trust straight from themselves to Hakadosh Baruch Hu

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CLOSING SECTION — Which Jobs Make Bitachon Easier or Harder

One final teaching on Category 3. Whenever working to provide the basics, one is obligated in **complete** bitachon:

trust in Hashem — **חובה מוטלת על הבוטח בהשם יתברך שבהשגת הצרכים האלו... ביטחון שלם בהשם** and **not** in the job you're doing to get these things.

But **the job itself affects how easy bitachon is:**

Three Kinds of Livelihood

Type	Examples	Bitachon
High-chance occupations	**דייג בים או צייד בשדה** — fisherman, hunter; raising animals, farming, seafaring	**Strengthens/eases bitachon** — the hashgacha is out in the open; success is visibly chance-dependent. Yaakov (posing as Esav, asked how he returned so fast): **כי הקרה ה' אלהיך לפני** — "Hashem made it happen before me"
Human-dependent occupations	one — **מי שתלוי פרנסתו במלך** whose livelihood hangs on a king (or a single patron/employer)	**Weakens/hardens bitachon** — everything depends on finding favor in one person's eyes. Hence David: **אשרי הגבר אשר שם ה' מבטחו ולא פנה אל רהבים** — happy is he who trusts Hashem and did not turn to the powerful
In between	general — **ההתעסקות במסחר** commerce, buying and selling	The middle path between the two

Contemporary Application (Rabbi Kada)

- **Modern "hunters"**: careers of near-total chance — an actor, a footballer — very hard to make it; those paths demand enormous bitachon
- **The other extreme**: a personal assistant to an extremely wealthy man — everything guaranteed through one human — bitachon is much harder
- **Self-employed vs. employed**: the self-employed person, whose finances shift day to day with clients and luck, generally needs (and more easily develops) more bitachon than the salaried employee with a fixed, predictable income

The Crucial Caveats — Trends, Not Rules

אין כוונתי לומר שכל המתפרנס באמצעות בני אדם או הון אי אפשר שיהיה לו ביטחון... ובכל זאת יש לפעמים ביטחון מלא גם במצב כזה

- Working for a king does **not** preclude bitachon — it's just **not easy**; reaching it there is a very high level:
- **Ovadiah** rose to the highest bitachon **while serving in the court of Achav**
- **David HaMelech**, with all his wealth, still said: **כי ממך הכל ומידך נתנו לך** — "everything is from You, and from Your hand we have given You"; **העושר והכבוד מלפניך**
- And **Iyov**: **אם שמתי זהב כסלי ולכתם אמרתי מבטחי** — "if I made gold my confidence..." — *not* to trust one's own fortune while possessing it is a great level
- Conversely, not every hunter or fisherman reaches the bitachon of Yaakov and Yitzchak — some leave it all to randomness and chance. **The point: in the former it's easier, in the latter harder — be cognizant of which kind of livelihood you're in.**

End of Category Three.

Summary

Question 1 — Hashem Feeds Even the Animals; Why Bitachon?

Because of **free will**: obedience broadens and eases parnasah (Ekev; כן יתן לידידו שנא); disobedience removes it (the curses; kefirim rashu; Chana; Doeg) or delivers it only through toil and war (Adam; Kayin; King Asa). The Mishnah in Kiddushin says it explicitly: **אלא שהרעותי את מעשי וקיפחתי את פרנסתי**.

Question 2 — Natural or Praiseworthy? Two Answers

1. **Kol = majority; bitachon is compelled or voluntary.** Most people reach bitachon compelled (no atheists in a foxhole — the ruined wealthy; even idolaters, whose service is an intermediary tracing back to Hashem: Yonah's sailors, Mesha of Moav). The praise-verses speak of the **voluntary** botei'ach — who chooses trust while he still has everything (and within the voluntary: the *general* feeling most of us have vs. the *rare, specific* bitachon lived out in every deal and every step — בכל דרכיך דעהו).
2. **Kol = literally all.** Everyone (humans and animals) trusts in something — wealth, strength, an employer, an owner — and every one of those traces back to Hashem: indirect, unknowing trust (the suckling analogy: mother → father → employer → Hashem; כי אתה גוחי מבטן). The praise is for trusting Him **directly**.

Jobs and Bitachon

High-chance livelihoods (hunter, fisherman — today: self-employment, acting, sport) ease bitachon; human-dependent livelihoods (serving a king — today: the fixed salary, the single patron) harden it; commerce is in between. But the trend can always be broken: Ovadiah in Achav's court, David in his wealth.

Coming Up

Monday: Category 4 — bitachon for important-but-non-essential matters (nice clothes, comfort). Preview of the principle: for **yourself**, the essential standard is basic food, clothing, shelter — **לא הרחבה ומותרות** — but this stringency applies only to one without a wife and family; **for those dependent on you**, bitachon beyond the basics is appropriate. And Category 5 (luxuries — "Hashem will make me a billionaire for my fancy cars") — certainly inappropriate, just like the mosquito (unless the aim is genuinely l'shem Shamayim, e.g., to build cities of Torah). The following Monday: the different levels of bitachon in Hakadosh Baruch Hu — completing the chapter before the break.

Next Thursday: the Rambam's understanding of Tisha B'Av.

B'Ezrat Hashem

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